search on the morning of 7 June that the bodies of Bhindranwale, Shahbeg Singh, Amrik Singh and Thara Singh were found in the basement. [22]

At about 4.30 a.m. on 7 June, Prem Kumar, special secretary (home), who was continuously monitoring the action by telephone and wireless from Amritsar, telephoned P.C. Alexander to confirm the report that Bhindranwale was dead and his body, which was lying in the basement of the Akal Takht, had been identified. The prime minister was immediately informed. [23]

The question of casualties

According to an army officer who was on duty at the makeshift cremation area just outside the temple complex, Bhindranwale was cremated at 7.39 p.m. on 7 June. A crowd of about 10,000 had gathered near the temple, but the army held them back. The bodies of Bhindranwale, Amrik Singh and Thara Singh were brought to the pyre. Captain Bhardwaj, who was on duty there, insisted on lifting the sheet covering Bhindranwale's body to identify it. When he asked the policemen why the body was so badly battered, they told him that the extremists had broken his bones. [24]

There is, however, some confusion over the timing of Bhindranwale's cremation, because as per the postmortem report the body was not brought into the mortuary until 7.30 p.m. on 7 June and was not examined until 8 p.m. According to the postmortem report, Bhindranwale was 'alleged to have died as a result of firearms' injuries'. [25] There are doubts about the accuracy of the postmortem reports. According to Shahbeg Singh's postmortem, his body was not brought to the mortuary until 9 June, and by then it was not possible to do a full postmortem of it because of the decomposition and putrefaction. There is no record of his last rites. He might have been cremated with the other bodies found in the hostel and temple complexes. Dead bodies from the complex had been piled into garbage trucks and taken to the cremation ground. [26]

The government white paper published in July 1984 said the army lost eighty-three men, including four officers. Twelve officers,